

Gowda now wants his son to chair the coordination committee meetings of the coalition's common minimum programme. He wants to retain control and not let the new Government alter any earlier decisions, which include the conversion of a proposed township project at Nandagudi, 55 km from Bangalore, into an SEZ and the proposal to float a Rs 50,000-crore township project in Bidadi, Kumaraswamy's constituency.

In fact, Gowda's shenanigans can throttle Yeddyurappa, if he is not careful. The JD(S)'s delay in joining the Government was a tactic to browbeat the BJP leadership into toeing his demands. Gowda will also keenly watch how the chief minister handles his detractors in Bellary, the former

chief minister Dharam Singh, who had headed the Congress-led coalition which had been ripped apart by Kumaraswamy in 2006, "It is not easy for people like Yeddyurappa to work with partners like JD(S) specially when they have diametrically opposite views on key political issues. You cannot afford to ignore Gowda when you are dealing with JD(S)."

Even Gowda does not go without his share of difficulties. There is pressure from within his family to appoint his other son H.D. Revanna as deputy chief minister although most of the 49 JD(S) MLAs favour Kumaraswamy. BJP, however, finds it easier to have dialogue with the "more reasonable" Kumaraswamy. He

state Cabinet. Even the 12-point letter to Rajnath had been prompted by the Congress's decision to cold shoulder him when he had demanded that M.V. Rajshekharan, a Lingayat and an old friend, be made the chief minister if Yeddyurappa did not make it. He had to work overtime to draft the letter after the political affairs committee of the Congress had indicated revoking President's rule in the state and holding mid-term elections, something JD(S) did not want.

For now, Gowda has won round one. He has been able to stem the huge sympathy wave in Yeddyurappa's favour after the initial JD(S) betrayal. Yeddyurappa, who had gone on a dharma yuddha, had never before seen such massive crowds like the



Lok Sabha constituency of Congress president Sonia Gandhi and now a BJP bastion. It was there that an attempt-to-murder complaint had been lodged by BJP legislator B. Sriramalu against Kumaraswamy. "I don't need BJP's support to fight these people, I will fight them on my own in the courts," says Kumaraswamy. However, Gowda will also want some action to be taken against BJP legislator Janardhan Reddy whose house and offices had been raided by income tax officials and who had promptly blamed Gowda for it. Says former

ON A LEASH: Yeddyurappa (R) may find Gowda's backseat driving irksome was the first person whom Yeddyurappa greeted after being sworn in—a symbolic gesture to convey that he would be the man to be sworn in as deputy chief minister along with 18 others from JD(S) on November 21, two days after the floor test in the Assembly.

The Chief Minister must be aware of the fact that Gowda likes backseat driving, something which he did with élan with the Singh-led Congress government. Gowda had ensured that his rival from the Vokkaliga community, D.K. Shivakumar, was kept out of the

ones he got now. However, Gowda sucker punched BJP with his offer of unconditional support, justifying it by saying that the Congress was trying to poach JD(S) legislators. And today, Rajnath is a happy man. At the swearing-in, he said, "I am confident we will not be betrayed this time. I expect them to keep their word. However, it is better to be betrayed than betray others." By making all the right noises, Yeddyurappa and BJP may have started well, but he and his ministers will have to watch over their shoulders, knowing that Gowda will be dogging every step of theirs. ■

GOWDA'S ORDERS

- All ministerial portfolios will be decided in consultation with Kumaraswamy.
- Government will have to give a commitment that the minority community will get full protection.
- The coordination panel will be headed by Kumaraswamy.
- Key administrative postings and promotions will be made in consultation with Kumaraswamy. Ditto for appointment of advocate general and senior law officers.
- No projects will be altered or annulled without consensus.
- If Lok Sabha is dissolved, both parties will be free to contest independently.